

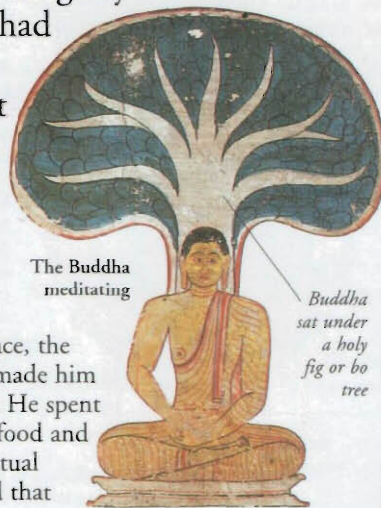
BUDDHA



BUDDHISM IS A WORLD faith that has changed the lives of millions of people. It began in Sakya, a small kingdom in northeast India. The founder of Buddhism was a prince, called Siddhartha Gautama, but today he is known simply as the Buddha, a title meaning "the enlightened one". When he was a young man, Siddhartha began a search for an understanding of suffering. By the end of his life he had become the Buddha, founded the Buddhist faith and already had many followers.

Enlightenment

When Siddhartha left the palace, the suffering he saw around him made him decide to become a holy man. He spent six years depriving himself of food and sleep, and learning about spiritual matters. Eventually he realized that this made him too weak for deep reflection, so he meditated under a tree. Here he made the breakthrough to an understanding of the truth known as enlightenment.

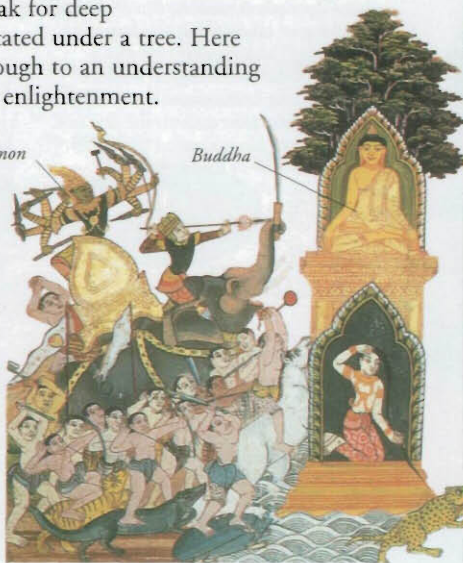


The Buddha meditating

Buddha sat under a holy fig or bo tree

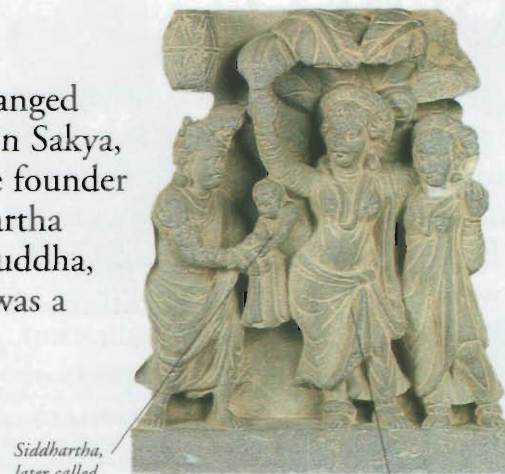
Temptations

While Siddhartha was meditating, a demon named Mara sent his beautiful daughters to tempt him from his chosen path. Mara also whipped up a storm and hurled thunderbolts at Siddhartha. But the young man carried on meditating, unmoved. He meditated for a whole night before understanding the truth, which he called *dharma*, and reaching peace, or *nirvana*, in his heart.



Mara, the demon

Buddha



Siddhartha, later called the Buddha

Maya, mother of the Buddha

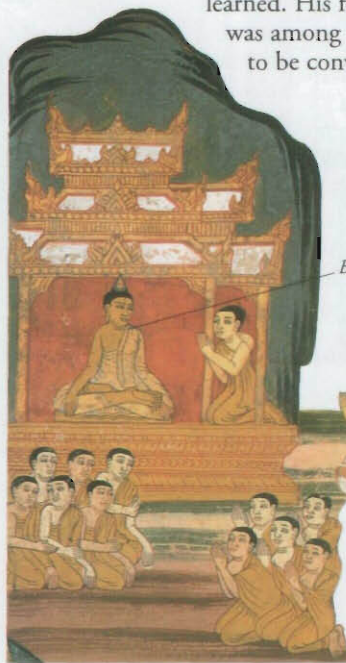
Early life

According to tradition, Siddhartha was born while his mother, Maya, was on her way to visit her parents. She died soon afterwards. His father was told that the boy would become either a great ruler or a Buddha. The king was afraid that Siddhartha would leave the court to become a holy beggar, so confined him to the palace grounds. But eventually he left to search for the true meaning of suffering.

Teaching

After experiencing enlightenment, the Buddha set out to teach others what he had learned. Many were converted, and the Buddha sent them away as wandering missionaries. Later, the Buddha returned to his father's court to teach his own people what he had

learned. His father was among the first to be converted.



Buddha



Sarnath

At Sarnath, near Varanasi, the Buddha preached his first sermon to five men who had previously sought enlightenment with him. He taught them that suffering is caused by desire, and to end suffering they must give up desire. Sarnath became the site of one of the greatest Buddhist shrines.

Bimbisara

Even during his own lifetime, the Buddha commanded so much respect that many people left their homes to follow him and form orders of monks and nuns. When King Bimbisara gave the Buddha a generous gift of land – "the gift of the bamboo grove" – Buddha's followers built the first Buddhist monastery there.

King Bimbisara

THE BUDDHA

Earliest records of Buddha's life were written more than 200 years after he died, so details are hard to verify. The following dates are accepted by most authorities.

563 BC Siddhartha Gautama, son of King Sudhodana of the Sakya, born in northeast India.

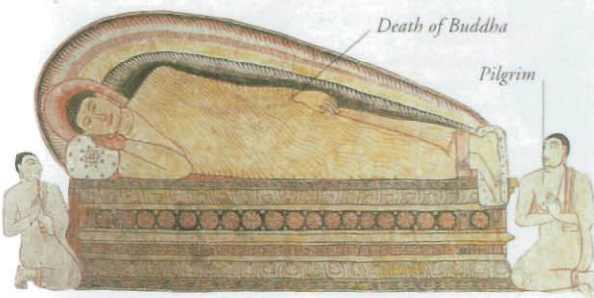
533 BC Siddhartha leaves his father's court to become a holy man.

527 BC Siddhartha attains enlightenment, and becomes the Buddha.

483 BC Buddha dies at Kusinagara, in Oudh, India.

Later life

When the Buddha was 80 years old, he ate some food that had been accidentally poisoned, and died at Kusinagara in India amongst his disciples. Many people came to pay homage to him. His body was cremated and the remaining bones were placed under stone mounds that have since become holy places of pilgrimage for Buddhists.



Death of Buddha

Pilgrim

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